

the spaces where
my voice once lived

written by: renj

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foreword

It's 3 a.m. again. The kitchen is dim, the light overhead flickering like it's unsure whether to stay or go. The fridge hums a low, persistent drone, a lullaby for the lonely, and somewhere on the counter, a spoon rests in a bowl smeared with something half-eaten, half-forgotten. You're sitting barefoot on the tiled floor, knees pulled close, a glass of water sweating in your hand. It's lukewarm now. You haven't spoken in hours—not out loud, at least—but your mind is loud enough for both of you. This room has seen breakdowns more intimate than love. This is where the unravelling always begins.

There's a kind of magic in how pain returns—familiar, like an old song in a new key. You remember how they left. You remember how you let them. The grief takes shapes here: in the breath you hold, the names you whisper, the silence you offer in place of explanations. Rage simmers on the backburner. Memory sharpens. These poems were not made to console. They are the static between stations, the bruise pressed too long, the scream caught behind teeth. They are everything you wanted to say but only found the words for too late.

These are the spaces where my voice once lived.

renj

Rehearsed plastic smiles for the public;
 The camera flashes love a glitter figure.
 Each shutter is a black hole that screams for more.
 The subject is anything but terrific,
 But that is the beauty of the stage's allure:
 Tragedy begets golden scars to adore.

The body for the worship of people,
 Flashy lights, dizzy heads, subtle smirks—
 One slip and fall, one big headline.
 Meticulous curation out of trouble,
 Steering clear of the people's topical irks,
 Hawk eyes are just around the sidelines.

Glass-grown skin, or else get tomatoes,
 Walking over the thick bills on the runway.
 The tarmac is your own dreams and wishes;
 The catch: you have to walk on your toes.
 In this city, there is no freeway,
 Catching every last cent as it vanishes.

Everyone is a rough head with iron fists;
 Make the least of everything for the most.
 Never frown, but cry—that's great for papers.
 Don't overdo it; that begets your opponent's feast.
 Real stardom is just a ghost;
 Once there, you get closer to the grim reaper.

Your death is dissected by the vultures;
 The nights you spend dreaming for more
 Are somehow now an even point for the coven.
 And you catch yourself dancing on a rotten culture,
 You ask for what's more in store—
 When you're there, there's no getting even.

very

getting even

cracks on the concrete

very

Will a lost heart be able to find its home,
One that is burned to the ground, into ashes?
A home that hung the best pictures up above,
The smiles that lingered through time,
Every touch of the wind that flushes,
All turned into forensics for men in gloves.

A cavity opened to scourge what's within—
Gone, never forgotten, existence to the heavens,
A name engraved in the title of a memoir,
Along with a now mischievous kind of grin.
Was the arson commissioned to get even?
Hatred, perhaps, that could fill a reservoir?

Will the lost heart ever find its true paradise,
A sea of porcelain color, washed by the Moon,
A tsunami shattering the soft, well-kept surface?
Beauty formed by tragedy may arise,
But it would never become what has been gone.
Will that be a hard truth for the heart to face?

Upfront and uphill battle to seek truth,
To find its true path to its forsaken abode,
A dedication enough to split continents apart,
A union of the universal forces against the ruth.
What's there left for it to decode?
Is there anything left for the lost heart?

Perhaps in wandering, it has found itself,
That the roads themselves are the paradise,
The cracks on the concrete are a story written,
And with the asphalt, the ashes ground.
That the smiles and touches were never in demise,
That the sea of tomorrow is actually within.

very

did it fulfill you?

Did it fulfill you?
The desire that wrapped you in,
The permission to let your guard down?
Did it elicit something from within—
warmth? A flame? An ember? A spark?
Did it feel like warm paradise in the dark?
Did its presence hold you tight in the park?
Did it fulfill you?

Did it fulfill you?
The world that was only painted in colors,
Apart from your monotone and regular?
Did it wash away traces of your despair?
Satisfaction? A wish? Longing?
Were you able to find what you were looking for?
Or was the light too much; was it piercing?
Did it fulfill you?

Did it fulfill you?
The candles that melted to the ground,
The ones you prayed on for what you wanted?
Did it make all your wishes granted—
Joy? Disappointment? Ecstasy? Turned blue?
Did it strike a new thirst within you?
Did it ever hold up like it used to?
Did it ever fulfill you?

very

half-thoughts

The nights I answered your call, I prepared for distress;
 The nights I offered my devils to the heavens,
 Full machinery to meet your half-thoughts by the terrace,
 Talking under the moon, while I played with kerosene.

And I know that I know better than anyone else,
 But the academics fall short of their own brains too.
 I know that you couldn't give anything, any piece,
 And yet I threw my whole existence into you.

The nights I forged my own signature to access myself,
 The nights when I got a papercut from the story we wrote,
 When you were stuck in limbo, and I jumped to help,
 And all I got was a half-thought promise and an off note.

And I know that I know better than anyone else,
 And that I know where all this winding will lead me.
 And I even gave you the keys to bring me hell,
 And yet I wish you to, for once, belong to me.

The night I was the one who threw you a question,
 The night you slendered off my queries to your own
 Half of myself there in the pits of aggressions,
 Yet I know you're the only nuisance I would not disown.

And I know that I know better than anyone else,
 But I kept mending the rustic string that connects us,
 Gave a whole lot to receive eight folds of hell,
 An agency on the ground, and a heart that was.

The night I got to put my heart into your shaky hands,
 The night you said you weren't ready for more.
 You held the beating red muscle bleeding on your hands,
 And my chest is now an empty store.

And I know that I know better than anyone else,
 But I do not know how to stitch back a human organ;
 And I lay on the ground echoing as it kills,
 Not the lack of my heart, but that you're now gone.

To snap at 3 AM, talking to the furniture,
 To assess the extent of my expenditure.
 All to the question of what was and what if,
 All for half-shut eyes to fall and slip.
 Unsteady hands grip a glass of red gold,
 The only light being the refrigerator's cold.
 A strange figure from the mist realizes,
 And the opening of my throat freezes.

crawling over shards of the broken night,
 All to the pleasure of my fight or flight.
 And when I touch it, it's gone.
 Was there a big, open fault line?

Will my bathroom mirror witness more of this
 When it turns from physical to arrest?
 No matter how I keep my knuckles far,
 On the excavations of our youth, they spar.
 No traffic lights at the street, but I stop
 To stare at the features that wrap you up.
 When the honks of the followers pierce through me,
 I'd rather stay and die than let the misnomer of you flee.

Pedals under my broken bones and time.
 Fragile midnights, miles of wander for a single time,
 To glimpse back onto the rest that once was mine.
 What kind of rift opened this fault line?

When I turn around and see the emptiness,
 My own mind creates your figure against the darkness.
 I try to ration my thoughts throughout my body,
 But all the pumping muscle does is to be greedy.
 Two people, one person in a suffocating smog,
 What wonder rained ashes and made us waterlogged?
 Would it wonder again and make sense of this tug?

Dying lightbulbs up on the streetlights above;
 Two people can build enemies from whom they loved.
 But we're no foes—we're indifferent landmines.
 And for my sanity, was the fault in between the lines?

very

fault line

Are you ready to battle with your words?
 After all the rages you grazed in my world,
 you want an entrance to which you coldly enter
 And have the last of my existence dismembered.

Tragic for you, I had long hung your name:
 A persona non grata among my circle of fame.
 Squeeze your hands on your loud trigger;
 Oh, the satisfaction of hearing cries get bigger.

And to your benefit, you would love being far.
 Come close, and you'll be one with the stars.
 All the sadness has turned into something red,
 And I never thought I could feel such hatred.

was the consumption of me all worth it?
 Because my wolves would find you insufficient,
 Trying to blend in and leech into my home
 That you claim has been your own.

And I know that this loss spreads on my body,
 But I'm sure that this loss for you is otherworldly.
 you could've figured that out before you did this,
 But here, I find your fall lower than this.

The streets have flipped sides on you, my dear;
 you're no longer someone to fear.
 Whether you've earned your spot there earnestly,
 My eyes would rather roll than answer honestly.

circle of fame

very

I throw up a month's worth on the floor,
 Knowing well I'd clean it by the morning,
 Trying to expel the stuff my gut displeases.
 I practiced you leaving through my door,
 But my blurry sight is of perilous mourning,
 I find you in the tiniest of creases.

very

Anything I could ask for, I questioned you;
 All that I am, I bore it all out to you,
 The truth braided in between my woes.
 I would watch you sleep until the sun's dew.
 What kind of coffee was I not able to brew?
 And it hurts that you just closed and flew.

Was it the lack of isolation that dragged you?
 Because I know I only have you when you sleep,
 When all you do is dream of possibilities.
 Did you think I wasn't capable of that for you?
 Because I poured all my wine into your grip.
 Falling is one thing, but crashing out is animosity.

You were here at some point, and you're still here:
 In the sheets, in the kitchen, in the pages.
 What best of mine became your worst?
 What pieces of me weren't you able to hear?
 What chapters haven't you released from your cages?
 And you walk away with all my bests and worsts.

My one, my many, my everything and nothing,
 All now trapped in your presence and existence.
 My appetite is exclusive and also elusive;
 The worst of my crimes crushed into somethings.
 Wasn't I the best during your limerence?
 I thought the whole lot of me was persuasive.

my appetite

very

I know a ripper who got me once and never let go.
 I did not know the exacts of her from and to.
 Should she dance once more in my porch light clear,
 Then I'd hold her back and never steer off.
 Adorned with a blue lace over her waves,
 Eyes that pierce through the lens of grief,
 With a smile that any lip would envy,
 The ones that leave you down on the floor.
 Have you seen the woman I was talking to?
 Oh, where did she go, my Saturn Blue?

A menace and by the book when she kills,
 With lungs that work to pump for the thrill.
 Should she sing and belong to me once again,
 Then I'd hold my breath until the end.
 She can tear apart what Hercules never could,
 And once you stare at her, you're stoned forever.
 Beauty or might, what I cling to, you decide.
 All I want is her back by my side.
 How I wish you had talked to her too.
 Oh, where did she go, my Saturn Blue?

saturn blue

I play tag with every shadow on the street.
 She would've figured out well if I left.
 Should she grace me again with her wisdom high,
 Then I'd caress her as we go on to fly.
 Breaking points are points of weakness for her;
 All knees crumble to simply adore her.
 No victors arise from the smile that puts you down;
 Her wavy hair pushes you in and makes you drown.
 How I wish I had been able to think this through.
 Oh, where did she go, my Saturn Blue?

A rope hung to traverse a river;
 Women clutching pearls, I remember.
 All to the thrill of the player,
 To hold on an unriveted prayer.

The bad thing was, everyone believed
 That the butterflies would somehow leave.
 But oh, the stomach was a conservatory,
 And with that, everyone wanted history.

Bleed, die, and be reborn to die again.
 Only one other could understand this then.
 Was it deeper than what had happened?
 Would it have changed if I had gone?

The worse part is that I believed
 That there is still a future to live,
 Whispered over the sighs and highs,
 And with that, 53 weeks fly.

The shadows cast by the tree,
 The echoes the running river remind me
 That my thoughts were not a mystery
 But a future I wanted to be.

False hopes on false promises,
 Ones I created in my own premises,
 To ideate on the facts of kisses,
 All night and as the sun pleases.

The worst part is, I still believe
 That somehow this could be relieved.
 And to add salt, I know that it's not;
 I know that it cannot.

very

that it cannot

very

standing on a rock

Three years from now, you'll look back
 At all the dominoes you've toppled behind,
 Check on the last men standing of the stack,
 Who remains alive, and who remains behind.
 And there you'll see me standing on a rock.

Provocations ushered by the perilous past,
 Undermining the landmines you've planted.
 When you thought all I am is rust and dust,
 You'll find what you've always wanted.
 And there you'll see me standing on a rock.

In a grocery store, when you pick the apples,
 When you ride the subway, board the ship,
 The road will shrink, and the water will ripple,
 You'll look back on the mountainous steep.
 And there you'll see me standing on a rock.

When time passes, the ideas turn to gold,
 Treasure to which I lay bare inside my satchel,
 Holding my breath as your guard's on hold,
 When this skin of earth turns supernatural.
 And there you'll see me standing on a rock.

When you're in jail for crimes against humanity,
 The whole world pointing cameras at you,
 Or at the prime of your career, or in infamy,
 In the richest, you try to find what you long for.
 And there you'll see me standing on a rock.

the silver screen

very

The silver screen makes your heart feel gold.
The stars have captivated us since days of old.
When the lights were low, I got you my own,
All that I harvested from the grit I had sown.

I remember the way you write an "o"
Or the way you screamed loud when you got bingo.
And the story was scarce, but the events were there,
And with your stature, that somehow felt fair.

We had to dodge the lights and flickers,
All the running and tugging, I remember.
Like fopes lost in a big forest, we bolted on wheels,
Like how those films spin on reels.

The silver screen made me feel so cold.
A routine of bleak appearances just unfolds.
And in the shadows of the light, I linger,
And at the height of sights, we just get to flicker.

I remember when you stormed your way out,
And we both know what it was all about.
And I get the point that you are entirely something else,
And it would matter now that our heavens are hells.

We had to run from the lights and standers.
All movies must come under.
Like fopes caught, we wag our tails to signal out,
And that was desperation and nothing but.

In between moments of public happenstance,
By the hanging gardens of lost second chance.
Two hearts mended over the Garden of Babylon,
And to feel is to ideate on what's beyond.

Sweetest position, oaths uttered in secrecy,
In between the cover pages of history.
A story written on pages old as time itself,
A masterpiece into which the select could delve.

was the garden ever real? For us, it was.
The choices made, to the midnight we entrust.
Paralyzed by the indecision between suns,
But when they had all gone, that was where we began.

And when I read and wrote deep into it,
My tears turned to ink, on the pages right and left.
Older I am than the writer I was; still, that was my best.
And between the cover pages, we had put that to rest.

Dust is now oceans, the sea floor is the book.
More than lines of text, no matter how I look.
I bathe in the indiscretions of mother nature,
Basking in the natural wear and tear it matures.

One would have never guessed the way it was;
I could not even fathom the end of us.
What the future glimpse offered me was nothing;
Specifically, nothing we could do would nurture the thing.

We filled the void between broad daylight with stars;
All streaks of them leave us scars.
But we shone so bright when all was asleep;
We soared high when we were buried deep.

Happenstance or not, it persists over the universe.
One of the unmended hearts pleads for a reverse.
But did the unwavering thinking ever do a thing?
And the presence, therefore, created longing.

the sea floor

very

Blue skies, clear intentions.
 Two souls on a ship in retention.
 Seagulls above their heads,
 Smiles all over their pleas.
 What they needed wasn't,
 And when the ship arrived, it wasn't.

A fate over troubled water,
 A fate under the sleeping Sun.
 A fate to dismember,
 A fate that came back to haunt.

Daylight running, blood pacing.
 Unlucky sights, unlucky longing.
 To forget is to remember to forget,
 And in memory, it is with breath.
 What they had wasn't in,
 What they have is within.

A fate over troubled water.
 A fate under the sleeping Sun.
 A fate to dismember.
 A fate that came back to haunt.

The tears, my cheeks, your feet.
 The smiles, my troops, your fleet.
 All came to drop on their knees.
 The skies, my wholes, your halves.
 The seas, my wants, your haves.
 All came back to haunt me.

A fate over troubled water.
 A fate under the sleeping Sun.
 A fate to dismember.
 A fate that came back to haunt.

a fate

very

burned the inside of me

very

I could not love you more than you could,
And you carried that whole thing throughout.
You could've left early on, knowing the fact.
I think you got through that by knocking on wood.
I wasn't sure if we would've made it out;
You never severed when I couldn't make pact.

I wanted to be tethered to you, just so you know,
But my best probably works the opposite.
See through my bones, and you'll see your name.
But I guess the right time eludes me somehow.
I could never create a future of us in composite,
Yet you stuck by the heat until consumed by flame.

I could give you everything, but I had nothing,
Scraped off by years of anticipating on a bright star.
A heart that glistened as the night started to fall,
Yet you saw the beauty in the flickering.
I knew for myself that I would never get us far,
Yet somehow, you had the courage to give it all.

When it felt like a lifeless mannequin,
You've managed to dress it up as someone warm,
Radiating the loss with the presence of growth.
And I whispered that you chase what's within,
That the person you're looking for isn't in your arm,
Not me whom you spend your life by the oath.

So when you left, it just made sense to me somehow,
And a stint of happiness burned the inside of me,
Not that you're gone, but because you're not with me.
I could not give you anything, and you're free now.
It's not a tragedy that you chose yourself over me;
In fact, it's the truth I wanted you to see.

very

red-eyed man

A red-eyed man dancing in a burning room;
One world stopped, four eyes lost,
Two eyes tearing, the other two closed,
The cry louder than that of the world's doom,
Two hearts on the edge of unrest,
Impressive performance from the verbose.

It's everything that we hoped and had—
Empty bottles, broken glasses, four lenses,
A dream, a start-up, and a wicked midnight,
Lit by a laptop screen, dancing like they're mad,
Acting over the hills of pretenses;
The future is not for us to perform a foresight.

A sober pair in an intoxicated haze of emotions,
The moving power of human connection.
I figured that I could never be happier then;
I still am the happiest when it comes to ideation,
And the way the curtains shape, gives reason
That somehow a piece of you isn't forgotten.

And so I burn my own room with enough tears,
Dancing on my assumption of your eyes.
In my last moments in this sober world,
I caress you back in my arms of fears;
If I could dispose of myself to acquire this prize,
Then I'd stick to that word by word.

Carefree, young minds on a boat.
 Chuckload of dreams for them to tote.
 On to a dream of greatness and victory,
 To emerge and be a permanent memory.

Situationships are just a side quest.
 Having the best of their times at rest.
 Unserious voices, superficial dreaming.
 Pastimes, and improper yearning seeming.

But two like souls burn each other out.
 Creating something unheard about.
 Deeper than the well of knowledge.
 The train tracks drizzled in prestige.

Four eyes crossing on a train wreck.
 A set of cards all familiar to the deck.
 And all of it was burning in red.
 Passion, trusts, and chin-up heads instead.

A good time to know each other well.
 To celebrate their birthdays as they fell.
 Age-old dreams of revitalization.
 Big fairy tales brought to realization.

But dreams do get in the way.
 Their hands not for them to play.
 Palm-reading each other's lifetime.
 Thinking they could share another lifetime.

And with that they get off the train,
 Drizzled by the familiarity of the rain.
 One last look into the eyes of each other,
 Strangers with the life of the other.

And they knew they had a good time,
 The only known legal crime.
 Someday, they will bump on each other,
 Strangers with the same things to remember.

very

improper yearning

the spaces where
my voice once lived

getting even
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